



Frayed welcome: Messi briefly waved to the Kolkata crowd before his appearance ended abruptly, triggering fan frustration that spilled onto the pitch, with banners and tents vandalised. DEBASISH BHADURI

So, when Messi's return was announced — this time via a private organiser with a well-documented history of chaotic events — the unease was immediate.

Credit must be given where it is due. Believing in the unimaginable and delivering it takes audacity. But memory matters. A 2012 exhibition featuring Brazilian and Colombian legends nearly collapsed over unpaid fees. Diego Maradona's 2017 visit descended into farce, and Emiliano Martínez, fresh from Argentina's World Cup triumph in 2022, had to escape in a police van from the Milan Mela convention centre after one of the windows of his car broke as fans mobbed him.

But this catalogue of embarrassments did not prepare us for December 13.

Thousands of fans, paying upwards of Rs. 4,500, waited patiently for a glimpse of Messi. What they got instead was a masterclass in entitlement. As Messi attempted a lap of honour, he was engulfed by a suffocating ring of political aides, relatives of ministers, and assorted gate crashers, much like the press conference 14 years back.

Inside the stadium, the State Sports Minister wrapped his arms around Messi like a defender illegally marking inside the box, busy collecting frames for his Facebook page even as the crowd grew restless, unable to see anything through the melee.

Still, they waited. Hoping, against instinct, that their elected representatives would step

aside and allow them their moment with *La Pulga*.

But the so-called VIPs tightened their grip, pushing even World Cuppers Luis Suarez and Rodrigo De Paul aside to get closer. Messi's irritation was visible. Twenty minutes into a scheduled 45-minute appearance, he walked away.

It was then that the stadium erupted. Not in joy, but in rage.

This was not just an organisational failure. It was a familiar moral collapse.

India didn't merely lose face in front of Messi. It revealed, yet again, how we treat sporting greatness. We see them as a prop for proximity, a backdrop for selfies, a means to manufacture relevance.

Organisers must be held accountable. But so must the ministers who rush to the front whenever a World Cup winner arrives, a franchise ends a title drought, or a medal is won.

Fourteen years ago, I argued these matches or occasions "should not turn out to be just a profit-making exercise for the visiting sides and promoters but stepping stones for the growth of the game in India."

This whole trip has just served the relentless hunger for reflected glory at the expense of the sport in the country. Even if a fraction of that money and interest was paid to Indian football, we wouldn't have seen it in such a sorry state today.